looked at détente as a peaceful coexistence between different political and social systems, as a need to prevent nuclear war and resolve disputes by peaceful means and mutually advantageous cooperation.

It is very difficult to give an exact meaning to such ambiguous concepts like détente. Nevertheless, the initiatives and serious developments that took place during the period of détente "were a far cry from sustained cooperation between the ideological antagonists, but they did signal a departure from the posture of confrontation that had previously typified Soviet–American relations. Cooperative behaviour was evident, however, intermittent and fleeting, amidst a pattern of continued competition for advantage and influence".[12]

Causes of Détente

Détente, as it came to occupy the centre stage of US–Soviet relations, naturally raised the question as to why both the superpowers suddenly sought détente or temporary relaxation of tensions. The point to be noted here of course is that before the Cuban Missile Crisis also there were attempts to ease tensions. After the Potsdam Summit, the two superpowers met in Geneva in 1955. Though there was no such pathbreaking achievements, yet the meeting was an expression of the altered climate between the East and the West, the 'spirit of Geneva' as it came to be known. President Eisenhower and Bulganin exchanged assurances that nuclear warfare had no rational purpose and both the powers were not interested in beginning such a war. Following the Geneva Summit, Moscow joined the Olympic Winter Games in 1956, negotiations on arms control also proceeded, though no final agreement was reached. The death of Stalin in March 1953 also brought about changes in the Soviet policy. Yet the spirit could not be carried forward due to the suppression of Hungarian revolution by the Soviets, the Suez Crisis and the German problem. But given the intensity of the Cuban Missile Crisis of 1962, which almost turned the Cold War into a hot war, the two superpowers gave a rethinking to their strategies towards each other.